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Cost-effective computing

on the logic that school children use just a fraction of an average PC's computing capacity, since their learning needs are quite simple. Setting up individual PCs for each student is therefore a waste of capacity and money. Hence, they set up 10 NComputing virtual desktops in each lab, which utilise the unused computing power of the PC and share with multiple users using NComputing's vSpace desktop virtualisation software. A keyboard, mouse and monitor are connected to each NComputing access device, making it appear as if each student has a PC to work on! Apart from the low hardware acquisition cost, the solution also meant 75 per cent less support and maintenance costs, and 90 per cent less energy consumption as NComputing devices use just 1-5 watts of electricity compared to 120-150 watts in a traditional PC. This is a critical advantage in remote parts of the state where power supply

is a perennial issue. In many ways, including cost, NComputing's solution seemed a best fit for rural India's computing needs.

There are lots more opportunities and even more ideas, if only we pause to think about the needs and income levels of the masses. According to a Press Trust of India release dated February 2013, after the unfortunate women harassment incidents in New Delhi, Union Minister of Communications & IT, Kapil Sibal, said to Rajat Moona, director general, C-DAC, "I want a wrist watch that will videograph, set up an alarm and will call up dedicated lines. Let's have a GPS system, and let's produce this watch for less than ₹ 1000 for the safety of the citizens of our country." Let us hope to see this and other ideas come to life, soon! ●

The author is a technically-qualified freelance writer, editor and hands-on mom based in Chennai

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